The Community and the Monument

The community in the area holds the monument in high esteem. An organised cultural group hold the annual traditional festival there. Participation are drawn from the nearby villages and the audience comes from across the country. The community believes that the monument was occupied by their great ancestors.

Restoration

A condition survey was carried at the site in 2003. The survey led to the eventual restoration of the wall with the cheque decoration in 2006. The access route (up hill steps) was also stabilised.

Flora and Fauna

The trees and shrubs found at the site were identified using the morphology of their stems and branches.

The eastern side of the site is characterized by a rocky landscape and is covered with some rock plants. These are mostly big trees and ferns. The western side is made up of sandy soil. It is occupied by sand loving plants, mostly Termanalia species.

Some Rules

Domboshaba is a National Monument administered by the Botswana National Museum and protected by the revised Monuments and Relics Act of (2001). Adherence to some basic rules will make your visit worthwhile and ensure the continued protection of a part of Botswana's unique heritage:

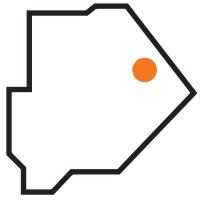
- Use the designated parking lot and report to the Custodians' office.
- Complete the visitors' book.
- Please do not interfere with the stonewalls or any other feature.
- Do not remove any artifacts.
- Please respect the local culture and leave objects at the site in their original place.
- Cooperate with the Custodians.
- Take litter away with you.

PLEASE NOTE:

Researchers and commercial photographers, contact the National Museum for more information.







Designation: Cultural
Area: approx. 3km²
Adoption priorities:
visitor interpretation centre, field assistants, signage, trails

For further information, contact:
The Archaeology Division, Botswana National Museum
Private Bag 00114 Gaborone, Botswana
Phone: +267 3974616 Fax: +267 3911186 / 3902797

DOMBOSHABA
monument

BOTSWANA national museum

ADOPT A MONUMENT
GIVING LIFE TO BOTSWANA'S HERITAGE SITES

DO201511

Cultural Heritage Site

DOMBOSHABA MONUMENT

Domboshaba literally means Red or Eland hill locally known as ‘Luswingo’. The site is located in the northeastern part of Botswana near Masunga. It is boardered by the Kalakamati – Masunga road to the south and Vukwi River in the Northeast. Domboshaba monument covers the hill top and the lower valley.

Domboshaba is found between Vukwi and Kalakamati villages. It is about 9kms from Masunga village and about 7km from Kalakamati. There is a tarred road which runs 500m from the site. The site is easily accessible.
The chief’s many wives are believed to have lived on the southern side where there is a big enclosure with lots of dakha floor structures. The chief lived on the hilltop with some of his assistants.

The site has been revered by the local people and has been protected by cultural taboos until the advent of colonialism. From that point onwards there was a lot of treasure hunting. The site was excavated by both treasure hunters and archaeologists. The excavations led to problems with regard to the conservation of both stone walls and daga structures. The most damaging were Frobenious’ 1928 excavations. He dug almost all the areas with stone walls. There is only one stone wall enclosure with some cheque decorations. This wall is on the lower valley area and was restored through sponsorship funds from the Africa 2009 programme.

The type of stone used for building the stone walls is granite with a few dolerite blocks. Dolerite could have been quarried within the environs of the monument as the presence of this type of stone was noted during an archaeological survey carried out at the monument. The common tree species in and around the monument are Mophane (Colophospermun mophane) and Mofafu. As a result of the vegetation, the mophane moth caterpillar (Gonimbrassia belina) is abundant at the site just after the rainy season.









Cultural and Natural Heritage

Domboshaba is an Iron Age site, which was occupied towards the end of the Great Zimbabwe period. It is an open site of more than 8 hectares. On the hilltop there are dry stonewalls which form private enclosures. Most of these stonewalls have an average height of 1.8 meters. The hilltop has six stone wall enclosures while the lower part has one main enclosure divided into several enclosures. Most of the walls are free standing with a few platforms, which mainly form part of entrances. There are 15 visible dakha floor structures, which represent the presence of huts.